



Asia

The largest of Earth's seven continents, Asia occupies one-third of the world's total landmass. It claims both the lowest and the highest points on the planet's surface. More than 4 billion people live here and it is home to the world's two most populous countries, China and India.

PETRA, JORDAN

Once a thriving trading centre, this unique city was carved into the pink sandstone rock face more than 2,000 years ago. Rediscovered in 1812, the entrance today is through the Siq, a long, narrow gorge flanked by high cliffs.



IMMENSE CARVING
The Monastery at Petra is beautifully carved and so huge that even the doorway is several stories high.

ANGKOR WAT, CAMBODIA

The temple of Angkor Wat is covered with exquisite carvings. Part of a vast complex of sacred monuments spread over 400 sq km (155 sq miles), it was constructed between the 9th and 14th centuries. Parts of the complex are now grown over by trees.

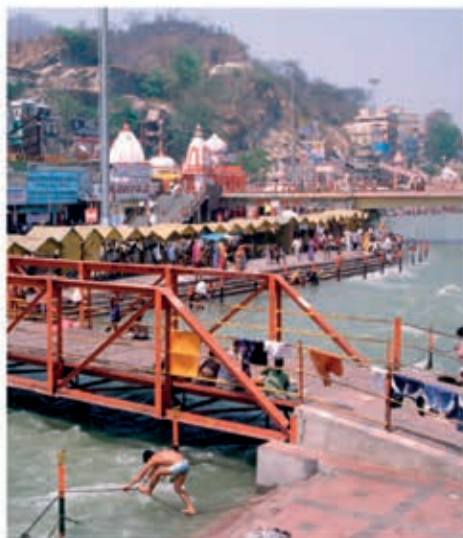


HINDU COSMOS

The temple is an earthly representation of the Hindu cosmos. Its five towers, shaped like lotus buds, form a pyramidal structure symbolizing the mythical Mount Meru, home of the Hindu gods.

RIVER GANGES, INDIA

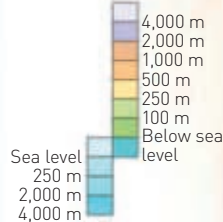
Starting in the Himalayas and finishing at the Bay of Bengal, the River Ganges is worshipped by Hindus as the goddess Ganga. The river is a lifeline for the people who live alongside it, but it has become heavily polluted by human and industrial waste.



HOLY BATHING

Pilgrims gather to bathe in the River Ganges at Haridwar, the "Gateway to God". It is one of the seven holiest places for Hindus.

KEY ELEVATION



▲ Mountain
▼ Lowest point

POPULATION

- Capital city
- Over 1 million
- 500,000 to 1 million
- 100,000 to 500,000
- below 100,000

TAJ MAHAL

The Taj Mahal was commissioned by Mughal emperor Shah Jahan in 1632 to house the tomb of his beloved wife Mumtaz Mahal.

MARBLE MONUMENT

Made of white marble, the colour of the building appears to change depending on the time of day.



IT TOOK 22 YEARS AND MORE THAN 20,000 CRAFTSMEN AND ARTISANS TO BUILD THE TAJ MAHAL